



Triumphant moment: Waldo Cortes Acosta (in pic) reacts after the fight against Derrick Lewis during UFC 324 at T-Mobile Arena. REUTERS

Despite absorbing a staggering 200-plus total strikes, Pimblett pushed Gaethje to the limit in the championship rounds, proving to critics that his skills belong at the elite level, even on the biggest stage of his career.

Ultimately, Gaethje's volume of offence and cage control earned him a unanimous decision, making him the first two-time interim champion in UFC history. He previously won an interim belt in 2020 when he defeated Tony Ferguson at UFC 249.

In the co-main event, Sean O'Malley reminded the world why he remains a perennial superstar, outpointing Song Yadong in a closely contested bout. The pendulum swung both ways in the opening rounds, with both fighters inflicting comparable damage.

It was in the final round that O'Malley's reach and precision timing began to overwhelm Yadong, sealing a decision victory. While O'Malley's position in the rankings remained unchanged at number

three, the win thrust "Suga" firmly back into the title conversation.

Meanwhile, the heavyweight division witnessed a passing of the torch, as Waldo Cortes-Acosta utilised his pace to stop veteran Derrick Lewis via a second-round TKO, signalling the arrival of a new threat in the big-man division.

Cortes-Acosta had entered the top five of the heavyweight rankings in the second half of 2025 after securing three wins in five fights.

This victory moves him a step closer to his maiden title opportunity.

Ultimately, UFC 324 was about the bigger picture of the sport's evolving narrative. While rising stars such as Pimblett and Song Yadong suffered setbacks, their performances reinforced the depth and competitiveness of the current roster.

For Gaethje, the win further solidified his legacy as one of the greatest lightweights to ever compete, setting the stage for a massive unification bout against undisputed champion Ilia Topuria.



Did you know?

The first-ever UFC interim champion was Randy "The Natural" Couture, who achieved the milestone at UFC 43: Meltdown on June 6, 2003.

At the time, the light heavyweight division was in limbo, with reigning champion Tito Ortiz sidelined due to injury and a high-profile contract dispute. To keep the division active and maintain momentum, the UFC introduced the interim title concept, pitting Couture against the then-rising knockout artist Chuck Liddell.

Despite being a heavy underdog and moving down from the heavyweight division at nearly 40 years old, Couture delivered a masterclass performance.

He utilised his signature "dirty boxing" to neutralise Liddell's power, eventually securing a TKO victory in the third round.

The win was historic not only for the belt itself, but also because it made Couture the first fighter in UFC history to win titles in two different weight classes.